

the senior side.

Her influence has extended strongly into franchise cricket. Keightley coached Perth Scorchers to multiple Women's Big Bash League (WBBL) finals, worked with Sydney Thunder's pathway programmes, and later joined SA20 franchise Paarl Royals, where she consistently pushed for greater female representation in coaching.

In the Women's Premier League (WPL), she was assistant coach at Delhi Capitals, finalists in all three editions so far, before a title-winning stint with Northern Superchargers in The Hundred in 2025.

From 2026, Keightley takes charge of Mumbai Indians, the two-time WPL champion, leading an all-women support staff. *Sportstar* spoke to her about the WPL, bowling challenges, and the broader growth of the women's game.

What drew you to Mumbai Indians from Delhi Capitals?

I was an assistant coach at DC, which was a fantastic experience. I enjoyed it from a different perspective, but I have always had the passion to be a head coach, and getting the opportunity to do that in the WPL was something I hadn't done before. So when the opportunity presented itself, I was very interested in pushing myself out of my comfort zone in another environment, in a different country.

The WPL is held in great regard within the Indian ecosystem for the competitiveness and opportunities it brings. How does the cricketing world outside view this league?

There are only a certain number of international players who get the opportunity. So watching from afar, they know how competitive it is. As an international player, you want to be a part of those competitions. I have a lot of players coming up to me who aren't here, asking me what it's like. Most players, at some point, want to play cricket in India because the people are so passionate about the game. To come and experience that is different from any other

competition in the world. The crowds, the hype, the involvement of the owners, it's all something special to experience. For an international coach or cricketer, it ticks a bucket-list box. Everyone wants to be involved in the best competitions in the world, and this is one of them.

How different is the WPL from the WBBL or The Hundred in terms of how embedded it is within the larger system of the country?

Each is different in different ways. In the WBBL, the domestic players are professional athletes. They've done the grind for several years. From that perspective, the domestic players across the board are probably a lot stronger. The WPL is new, while the WBBL has been going for 11 seasons, and that contributes to greater experience among the domestic crop there.

The Hundred is a different entity. Different rules and different concepts, which is a nice change, to be honest. You also play alongside the associated men's team. There is scope for a lot of crossover and interaction, which you don't get in other leagues. The crowds are great, too.

The WPL is also different. It is frantic, busy, and everyone constantly wants a piece of you. You don't get the kind of crowds you see here elsewhere. In India, the boundaries are small, and conditions are tough with the dew. It adds to the challenge levels. We have three fantastic competitions for women in the world, and that can only mean good things for the game.

It's a batter's world in T20 cricket today. How can a coaching staff better support bowlers with pitches increasingly favouring higher scores?

The bowlers have to be very resilient. They need to be able to bowl a delivery, park it regardless of the outcome, and come back and execute the next ball. Dew helps batting at night and the smaller boundaries add to that. It makes this competition one of the hardest in the world for domestic and international

seamers.

The job, then, is to temper expectations. We're realistic about when bowlers have had a good day and when they haven't, and it's really hard to have good days, particularly when your role is in the PowerPlay or at the death. That's why it's so important to have experienced bowlers who you know can handle those two phases. That's what we look at when building teams. You need experienced bowlers who can cope under that pressure.

An ambition for India has been to use the WPL to build a competitive pace-bowling pool. Don't these conditions make that harder?

It's really hard because at this level, if you don't execute your skill, you're probably not going to get the opportunity to do it again, or you could end up on the bench. On one hand, coaches and owners need to understand where bowling is at and give opportunities to potential seam bowlers who can grow within this competition. It's hard to do because, at the end of the day, you want to win. If your bowlers can't execute, they probably won't get too many chances, because the ultimate aim is to win the competition.

Kranti Gaud and Renuka Singh are good examples of players who can manage that responsibility through good days and bad. If they can do it here, they can do it anywhere in the world.

Indian cricket's philosophy is usually spin-dominated. In the women's game, if you can take pace off and make batters create the pace to get the ball over the rope, it creates wicket-taking opportunities too. It's a tricky balance. When we work with our bowlers, we also try to get them to make peace with conceding 10 runs an over. That framing is important.

You might feel you've been expensive, but in the context of the game, you may have done your job. It's about educating players and being realistic about what is good enough on that day.

Bowlers are now expected to